‘modern and rational mainstream’ and had to prove itself on the judgemental anvils of the latter. The native worldview could never succeed at proving its ‘modern’ relevance because the coloniality/modernity/rationality complex was *designed* either to exclude indigenous perspectives, or acculturate it in case it happened to be of value, without crediting the indigenous perspective. According to Quijano, this is where the true genius of the European coloniser lay—not in the brutal economic and political repression of the native, but in successfully projecting his way of life as the aspirational ideal. The blanket consumption of this idea by the dominant native elites served to alienate them from the rest of the colonised society. As a consequence, if a fault line existed in the colonised society prior to the arrival of the European coloniser, the active co-option of the elites in the dominating power structure as well as the worldview of the coloniser only served to deepen the fault line. If a fault line did not exist hitherto, it was consciously created. In either case, the fault lines remained even after decolonisation as the legacy of colonialism.

That said, the coloniser was not content with the co-option of only the dominant elites among the natives but was interested in converting the entire native society to his way of life. To this end, Quijano pointed out that while the coloniser saw the colonised society as an economic resource to feed on, he also indulged in the systematic and extensive repression of indigenous ideas, beliefs, images and knowledge, including the systems of production of knowledge. This deprived the colonised society of its ability to respond culturally, even if it did not have the wherewithal to resist politically or militarily. Since most native elites that were at the helm of the centres of culture and production of knowledge had surrendered their agency over the indigenous worldview, the masses too gradually followed suit. The cumulative effect was the deep embedding of coloniality in the consciousness of the colonised society, so much so that it started believing that it had been defeated *because* of its cultural moorings. To the colonised and now *colonialised* native, it seemed that the only way to regain dignity was by adopting European culture and thought processes, which included the European way of achieving economic prosperity, that is, by exploiting nature. This disruption of the critical relationship between indigenous societies and nature came to affect the entire world.

Apart from the disastrous impact on nature, the universalisation of European culture made it *the* benchmark against which all other cultures